EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Does Reason Prove There Is a World to Come?

Given Monday 1 September 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 9:1

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 9 (Reward and Punishment in the World to Come), Chapter 1

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 1 September 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Back After the Summer

"I hope you've had a refreshing August and a good break." The series began in January 2024, so it is now close to two years in. The plan is to finish the book by the end of this calendar year and begin a new sefer in January. This is **the final philosophical essay**; Essay 10 will be "something different."

Where We Are: The Whole Book So Far

Essay	Subject
1	**Creation**: the world was created; it is not pre-existent or eternal. Saadia begins with the world before discussing God
2	**What we mean when we speak of God**: His unity, and the descriptions of Him in the Torah
3	**Revelation**: the Creator reveals His will and gives commandments; the kinds of mitzvot; the truth of the Torah
4	**Free will**: who says we can make those choices? Free will and God's knowledge
5	**Mitzvot and sins**: how a person is classified by a majority of merits or sins, and why those with more mitzvot do not always seem to have the best lives
6	**The soul**: its nature, its elements, its creation
7	**Techiyat HaMetim**
8	**The redemption and Mashiach**
9	**Olam HaBa**

The book has three parts: **God**; **God's relationship with humans** (mitzvot, revelation, the soul); and **the end of times** (resurrection, Mashiach and, finally, Olam HaBa).

The key point leading into this essay: **everything in Essays 7 and 8, resurrection and both redemptions, takes place in this world.** Saadia held there are two redemptions, one through Mashiach for Am Yisrael, and one for all humanity. **Olam HaBa is something completely different.**

What Essay 9 will cover

Eleven chapters, among them:

- **Chapter 1** (tonight): what Olam HaBa is, and proofs **from reason** that it must exist.
- **Chapter 2:** proofs **from the verses**, and the major question: if there are hints and sources for Olam HaBa, **why is it never mentioned explicitly in the Torah**, and why does the Torah's reward always seem to be physical, in this world, as in the Shema we say every day? There are **seven approaches** among the Rishonim, which the **Abarbanel** "beautifully brings" together. That will take a whole shiur.
- **Chapters 3 and 4:** rabbinic tradition about Olam HaBa.
- Later: Is there **time** in Olam HaBa? Is there **service**, even **mitzvot**, in Olam HaBa? "Now you may be thinking to yourself, of course there isn't. You'll be surprised." And Saadia even dares to describe the **nature of the reward**, with **seven levels of pleasure**, something the Rambam refuses to discuss, and on which the Ramchal gives only a very limited understanding.

Two Views of Olam HaBa

Before the text, the Rabbi set out Saadia's view, "which is the view of the majority of the Rishonim."

Saadia (with the Ramban, the Ramchal and many Rishonim)

1. **Olam HaBa is a new world.** It does not exist now. It is called "the world to come" because it will be **created in the future**. All the wonderful things discussed over the past months, the redemption, resurrection, Mashiach, Eliyahu, the Beit HaMikdash, "they're all happening in *olam hazeh*." Saadia takes literally the Gemara that this world lasts **6,000 years**. "We're about to begin 5786. So even if Mashiach comes today, we've got maximum 214 years of enjoying all of these things." "We're running out of time. That's the reality."
2. **It is enjoyed by body and soul together.** The body took part in the mitzvot, in building a better identity in this world, so it is only right and just that it share in the reward. As Essay 7 explained, those resurrected in the Messianic era are not resurrected again; they are **transported over** into the new world.

The Rambam

1. **Olam HaBa already exists.** It is called "the world to come" not because it has not yet been created, but because it **comes after** this world for each person. "It has been created already, but we haven't reached that yet."
2. **There is no body in it.** For the Rambam, a bodily Olam HaBa is a contradiction in terms: its whole essence is something the body cannot enjoy.

Reward in three places

Saadia also said, in Essay 5, that there is some reward and punishment **in this world** (though some Gemaras say there is none, or only a little), and, in Essays 7 and 8, that one's share in the redemption and resurrection will be **commensurate with one's level**, so there is consequence **in the Messianic era** too. But the major, most perpetual reward is **Olam HaBa**, and that is the subject now.

Question: who merits it?

Richard asked whether Olam HaBa is reserved for the most righteous, or available to all except those who have done something bad. Saadia never discusses numbers, "but I don't need Saadia, because the Mishnah tells you": **כל ישראל יש להם חלק לעולם הבא**, except very specific categories. The presumption is that **the vast majority** of Jews will be there. The **Ramchal** writes explicitly in Derech Hashem and Da'at Tevunot that only **מעט מזער**, a tiny few, will have no portion. People know the line from Shabbat morning, where it is quoted with **ועמך כלם צדיקים** and then cut off, so they think every Jew has a portion. "But you haven't seen the next part, which says: apart from." Still, those excluded are the minority.

Gemul, Not "Reward"

The essay is titled **בגמול ועונש**, usually translated "reward and punishment." The Rabbi does not like the word "reward," because it suggests you do something and get paid: "A child does something, you pay the child five pounds."

What is the root of **גמול**? A participant answered: to bestow. And that, said the Rabbi, comes from **גמל**, a camel.

- We say in the Amidah **גומל חסדים טובים**. "Is there *chasadim ra'im*? There is bad kindness": kindness with no limit, which keeps the other person dependent.
- The camel is "the quintessential animal which is able to live off itself for months. It drinks, and then that's it." The independent animal.
- True kindness, *chasadim tovim*, lets the other person build their own identity and live their own life.

So *gemul* is not "I did X, therefore I get Y." **"This is just who I am. This is the consequence of the kind of person I've created for myself."** *Onesh*, by contrast, is punishment, and Saadia will ask a striking question about it later: why is it not enough for Hashem to give Olam HaBa to those who merit it? Why must He punish those who do not?

Chapter 1: The Day of Distinction

הודיענו אלהינו יתברך ויתעלה כי כבר קבע זמן לגמול הצדיקים, ובו יבדיל בין הצדיקים ובין הכופרים

Hashem has fixed a time to reward the righteous, when He will distinguish between them and the deniers:

והיו לי אמר ה׳ צבאות ליום אשר אני עשה סגלה... ושבתם וראיתם בין צדיק לרשע, בין עבד אלהים לאשר לא עבדו (Malachi 3:17-18)

Saadia understands that day as **Olam HaBa**. The prophets confirmed it with signs and wonders, and he will show that it is necessary **from reason, from Scripture and from tradition**.

Where is Gan Eden?

The Rabbi noted that **Saadia never uses the term גן עדן** anywhere in the book. He speaks of resurrection, redemption and Olam HaBa, but not Gan Eden. Where does the concept come from? Is it one concept or two? The Rambam, following the Gemara, seems to treat *gan* and *eden* as two things. That discussion belongs to the new Tuesday series on the Rambam's introduction to Perek Chelek, starting the next evening.

The human at the centre

כי השמים והארץ ומה שביניהם לא נבראו כולם כי אם בעבור האדם

Saadia recalls Essays 4 and 6: everything was created **for the human being**, which is why he is placed in the middle with the worlds surrounding him, like the important part of an egg in its centre. "Obviously we know nowadays that isn't correct, at least in terms of the astronomy." The Ibn Ezra and the Rambam disagreed with him, "and they were proven right, at least astronomically."

That is why the human was given a superior soul, with intellect and wisdom, and was commanded with mitzvot and prohibitions, as a preparation for **eternal life**. That life will begin when Hashem has finished creating all the people He wishes to create. Then He will settle us in **another world** and reward us there.

Seven Proofs from Reason

1. This world is too mixed to be the goal

שכל טובה שיש בעולם יש עמה רעה, ועם כל הצלחה עמל, ועם כל הנאה צער, ועם כל שמחה יגון

Hashem, in His wisdom, justice and goodness to His creatures, would not make **this world** the final reward of the soul. In this world:

- every good comes with some bad;
- every success comes with toil;
- every pleasure comes with pain;
- every joy comes with sorrow.

At best it is equal, and really the world tilts more towards difficulty and sadness than happiness. So it would be absurd for a wise Creator to make the soul's ultimate benefit its days of toil and fear. **There must be another place**, with complete life and true happiness.

"This is a very pessimistic view of the world," the Rabbi said, but the idea was echoed by many later. The **Ramchal** opens **Mesillat Yesharim** with it, and develops it in Derech Hashem: every good in this world is coupled with something negative, so this world cannot be the end product. If we die at 120 and that is the end for eternity, "God hasn't done a good job." "You know, just today, 800 people died in an earthquake." Everyone works hard and has troubles. "There must be something more."

The Rambam disagrees with the premise

The Rambam does not necessarily reject this as a proof of Olam HaBa. What he rejects is the claim that **the world has more evil than good**. In the Moreh (3:12) he writes that people, even the wise, often think so, and he singles out **al-Razi**, who wrote a well-known book which,

"amongst other mad and foolish things," argued that human existence is a punishment. (The Rabbi observed that if you really believed that, taken to its logical conclusion, "what's the purpose of living?")

The Rambam's answer:

- **The error is judging the universe by one person.** An ignorant person thinks the universe exists for him, so when something goes wrong he concludes the whole universe is evil. Look at the whole, the spheres, the stars, the elements, minerals, plants, all species, and humanity is an infinitesimal part of it.
- **Most of the evils we suffer we bring on ourselves**, by our own free will, and then blame God, who is far from them. The man who weakens his sight by excess and goes blind; the man who falls ill from bad food.

"Now you may say, there are natural tragedies which have got nothing to do with the human. That's a question, that's discussed." But that is the Rambam's view.

2. No soul is ever at rest

> **כי אני מוצא כל נפשות בני אדם אינן נחות בעולם הזה ולא בוטחות, אפילו מגיע לגדולת המלכות ולרחבת הממון**

Saadia speaks from experience: the people he has met are never truly settled or secure, **even those who reach kingship and great wealth**. No one says, "I've reached utopia." This is because the soul **knows there is a more honoured place** and longs for it. If not for that, it would be calm and tranquil.

The Rabbi asked the class for their own views: "Very much what he said so far has been quite subjective."

3. We condemn what we desire

Human nature desires things that the human intellect condemns: **promiscuity, theft, arrogance, revenge** and the like. When a person controls himself and holds back, it costs him: he is pained, upset, frustrated. Why bear all that? **Only because he expects good at the end.**

The Rabbi drew this out: almost everyone, even many who do these things, recognises that they are objectively wrong. "Where does this wrong feeling come from? Only, says Saadia, because I know there's Olam HaBa."

The Rambam's ideal is different

He recalled the **Shemonah Perakim**, the Rambam's introduction to Avot, studied over a year earlier. The Rambam distinguishes:

- **Rational mitzvot**, which we would know anyway (theft, honesty, honouring parents): here the ideal is to reach the point where **you no longer desire to do wrong at all**. At the start you may need *yirat Shamayim*, "Hashem said I can't," but ultimately the temptation itself should go.
- **Revealed mitzvot**, which we would not know without Hashem telling us, such as kashrut: here it is fine, even commendable, to say, "I wish I could eat non-kosher, but Hashem said I can't."

Saadia seems to assume a **lifelong battle** with temptation. If the Rambam's ideal is reached, "this whole proof would fall apart," unless Saadia is speaking of most people for most of their

lives rather than the ultimate state.

4. We praise what costs us

The converse: the intellect approves of **justice and uprightness**, of doing good and of warning others away from bad, even though people get angry when you correct them, and it can bring insults, even blows. "If someone genuinely takes someone aside and cares for them and tells them to improve their behaviour, sometimes it can rebound." Why would anyone do it, and why do we know deep down that it is right, **unless there is a great reward to come**?

5. Wrongs between people go unrighted

We see people wrong one another, and then both die, with no justice. Since Hashem is a true judge, there must be **another place** where the one who suffered is compensated and the one who caused pain pays for the pleasure he took. This is about personal interactions between people, not yet the general question of the righteous and the wicked.

6. The righteous suffer and the wicked prosper

כי אנחנו רואים כופרים בנעימים בעולם הזה ומאמינים בצער בו, ואי אפשר שאין להם עולם אחר

"This is one of the greatest questions against religion." Saadia **turns it into a proof**: if the righteous suffer and the wicked thrive here, there must be another world where each receives his due.

7. One death for one murder or ten

Under capital punishment, a person who killed once before witnesses is put to death once. A person who killed ten times, or committed adultery twenty times, and was only caught the last time, is also put to death once. "Where's the justice in that?" There must be another place where it is played out properly.

Then Why Not Start in Olam HaBa?

ואם יאמר אומר: ולמה לא היה טוב שיברא הבורא את האדם הזה בעולם האחר מתחלה, ויניח לו כל הצער?

If reason proves Olam HaBa, why not take us straight there and spare us the troubles of this world? Saadia answers in a single line: **as explained in Essay 3.** The Rabbi asked who remembered the answer. A participant gave it: **a person needs to earn it himself.** Earned reward is greater.

That, said the Rabbi, brings us back to the word **גמול**: the camel, independence. "You've earned it, you've chosen it, it's yours, as opposed to just being thrust upon you and given to you without doing anything."

Summary

1. **Structure:** Essays 1-2 on God, 3-6 on God and humanity, 7-9 on the end of times. Resurrection and redemption happen **in this world**; Olam HaBa is something else.
2. **Saadia** (with most Rishonim, the Ramban, the Ramchal): Olam HaBa is a **new world**, created after 6,000 years, for **body and soul**. **The Rambam:** it **exists now**, after death, for the **soul alone**.

3. **Who merits it:** *kol Yisrael*, apart from specific exclusions; per the Ramchal, only a tiny few miss out.

   is not payment but the consequence of who you have made yourself, like the self- **גמול** .sufficient **camel**

5. **Seven proofs from reason:** this world is too mixed to be the goal; no soul is ever at rest; we condemn what we desire; we praise what costs us; wrongs between people go unrighted; the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper; one death for one crime or for ten.
6. **The Rambam** rejects the premise that evil outweighs good in the world (Moreh 3:12), and his ideal of overcoming desire for moral wrongs (Shemonah Perakim) would weaken the third proof.
7. **Why not begin in Olam HaBa?** Because it must be **earned** (Essay 3).

Coming Up

Next week, at the usual time of 6 o'clock: **Chapter 2**, the proofs from the verses, and why the Torah does not mention Olam HaBa explicitly. The Rambam series on Perek Chelek begins the following evening.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/-frjXD4DFFo · More shiurim: rabbikada.com